

disgrace to their town and families, the couple were forced to flee to Milan, where their son Antonio was born. Payments from Ricordi kept the composer's illicit ménage alive, but only just—an experience of poverty that Puccini was to draw on when writing his opera *La Bohème*, with its cast of impoverished would-be artists.

“ I am a **mighty hunter of wildfowl,**
beautiful women, and good libretti. ”

GIACOMO PUCCINI

In 1891, Puccini discovered a rural retreat at Torre del Lago on Lake Massaciuccoli in Tuscany. There he could work in peace on his third opera, *Manon Lescaut* (based on a novel by Abbé Prévost). Adapting Prévost's work, Puccini ran through five librettists in search of the ideal combination of drama, words, and music. The effort proved worthwhile. From its premiere in Turin in 1893, conducted by Arturo Toscanini (see [box](#)), this dark story of a doomed femme fatale was an overwhelming hit, establishing Puccini as Italy's most promising successor to Verdi.